NASM VIRTUAL COACHING SPECIALIST (VCS)

Chapter 4: Communication and Coaching Strategies

National Academy of Sports Medicine — Evidence-Based Telehealth Curriculum

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies
Lesson 1Virtual Coaching 101

Communication is necessary to establish and maintain a trusting fitness professional–client relationship. The convenience and efficiency associated with online communication are equally matched by the difficulties of establishing credibility, building client relationships, and motivational coaching. This chapter will review best practices for virtual communication from the initial visit to explaining programs and maintaining compliance.

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

- **Determine** how to use virtual communication platforms to establish the fitness professional-client relationship.
- **Discover** ways to build rapport, motivate, and set goals virtually with a client.
- **Analyze** client accountability in a virtual environment.

Introduction

Communication plays a tremendous role in the relationship fitness professionals have with their clients. With in-person training, fitness professionals often rely on a combination of non-verbal and verbal communication strategies to relay instructions, cues, incentives, and enthusiasm. However, there has been a shift in fitness service offerings due to advances in technology and alterations in lifestyle factors. In-person training environments are now also offered in hybrid or fully virtual, online training formats. Therefore, fitness professionals should be familiar with various forms of communication and learn how to tailor different technologies and methods of communicating to achieve greater success for their clients.

Online platforms have opened more environments and increased opportunities to cultivate client relationships to help clients reach their goals. The fitness professional should work at not only developing the technical skills to navigate online training, but also how to interview, build rapport, and set goals with clients. While there are many common elements between in-person and online training, there are distinct differences as well—requiring fitness professionals who train clients virtually to place greater focus on developing skills to combat distraction and maintain excellent client connection.

This chapter will address core principles of virtual communications. The fitness professional will be able to use this information to guide interactions with clients from consultation to regular check-ins. While the technical aspects of training, like data collection and sheet creation, are important to working and tracking progress with clients, ultimately, it all comes down to the relationship the fitness professional is able to build and maintain with the client.

Virtual Communication 101

Any method where individuals use technology to communicate with each other without meeting face-to-face is considered a **virtual environment**. These environments will vary based on services provided and the technology available for the fitness professional and potential clients. It is estimated that roughly 81% of Americans go online daily with upwards of 43% going multiple times per day (Perrin et al., 2018). Fitness professionals have the ability to reach millions of people online and to help them shape their goals using a wide variety of communication platforms.

Advantages and Disadvantages

Fitness professionals who offer, or plan to offer, virtual programming and coaching services must understand the advantages and disadvantages of virtual communication. There can be misconceptions regarding working with clients online, from a distance (i.e., thinking it is easier due to the ability for fitness professionals to stay in their home or gym while working with the client). However, for every advantage virtual training may afford, there may be an equal number of disadvantages (**Table: Virtual Communication Advantages and Disadvantages**). The fitness professional should take stock of the range of potential issues they will face using a distance coaching platform.

Virtual Communication Advantages and Disadvantages

Advantages	Disadvantages
Clients can reread instructions and guidelines.	Can lack in-person connection and interpretation of body language.
Clients can provide in-depth details regarding their needs or questions.	Can lack immediate feedback depending on communication format.
Fitness professionals can provide in-depth details regarding their plans and instructions.	Some clients or fitness professionals may find lack of in-person communication more challenging.
Materials and records are easily stored.	Some clients may not take a virtual commitment as seriously as an in-person commitment.

Both the client and fitness professional have time and opportunity to collect and articulate their thoughts.	Tonality may be lost or misconstrued in text-based communication.
Fitness professionals can reach a wider audience. Clients have vast resources and have the ability to stay in their own environment (Khorzoghi et al., 2018).	Some less technologically savvy clients may struggle with navigation of online platforms.

Virtual environment

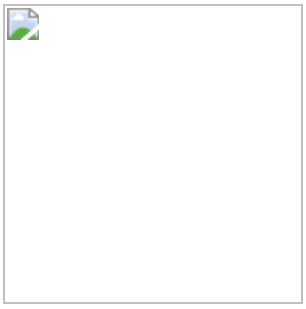
A method where individuals use technology to communicate with each other without meeting face-to-face.

Communication Platforms

The method the fitness professional uses to connect with a client will depend on the technical aspects of their online setup and if they work for themselves or with a company. There are a variety of communication platforms the fitness professional can use; in fact, it is not uncommon to use more than one to service clients. It is important to understand how each platform works in order to assess which one will work best for the fitness professional and their clients depending on the situation and program needs.

For example, one type of communication platform is a mobile app. NASM's EDGE app allows fitness professionals to access client information, use and perform assessments, and tailor workouts all from one platform interface. While this app services a certain set of needs and requirements, each fitness professional will want to determine the right system and communication platform from which to deliver their programs and services (**Table: Communication Platforms**).

Communication Platforms

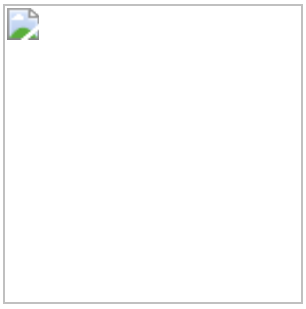


Email is the most common application for communicating with online clients. In 2018, over 281 billion emails were sent and received each day (Clement, 2019). It is also the most personal form of virtual communication and often easy to use. In its most simple use, an online fitness professional needs only an email address to start working with clients virtually. Using email for client communication comes with many benefits, including accessibility. For instance, when people go online, they often start with e-mail.

Email also decreases the chance of technology fumbles and errors or the need for third-party communication systems. Email provides a clear one-on-one platform for talking between clients and fitness professionals and builds a foundation for confidentiality and trust in the relationship.



Online communities or apps can include private company memberships or social media platforms like Facebook. With private company membership, a fitness professional can have their own membership site or app where individuals can access their information and update and share results with their fitness professional and often other members. With certain apps and membership groups, fitness professionals have the capability of delivering programs, exercise videos, and nutritional information and to track their client's data while also allowing the client to see and track the data themselves.



With social media supported groups like Facebook, individuals can receive support, links, and updates just as with the private community; however, the fitness professional and company leader do not control the design or updates of the space. There are also few ways to track data or performance. Fitness professionals may be limited based on what they want to execute and how much they can achieve. There is also an increased possibility of distraction or disruption in goals due to the other elements that exist with and comprise social media. That being said, the collective community provided with social media can be inspiring and unifying.



Text messaging (texting) is a form of communicating with the client directly via the messaging application on mobile devices, which essentially bypasses e-mail. It gives direct written messages to the client, usually instantly. Fitness professionals can use texting to provide or receive immediate answers to questions or for reminding clients of goals they need to achieve for the day. Reminders are a particularly interesting point of focus for fitness professionals as some studies show that texting or mobile app messaging may help increase attention toward health goals (Schwebel & Larimer, 2018).





A growing technology trend in client communication is video calls and video conferencing between fitness professionals and clients. Smartphone applications like FaceTime or WhatsApp or online conferencing services like Google Hangouts or Zoom means fitness professionals can interact with and watch their clients perform workouts and then relay comments or advice based on body language and non-verbal cues. Moreover, fitness professionals can visually demonstrate, just as they can in-person, how to perform exercises and movements correctly.

These applications will often have recording options, which can allow the fitness professional to replay calls and take more time to analyze and dissect assessments. Furthermore, fitness professionals can use these videos as “before” examples to measure and track client results against, allowing them to show progress to the client as time goes on.



The phone is still a solid standby for quick, easy, and instantaneous communication. While not all client populations may have access or the technological ability to use video or application services, a large majority do have telephone access. Fitness professionals and clients can communicate their needs and instructions and provide instant responses.

Synchronous and Asynchronous Communication

Fitness professionals should consider which environment and type of communication is the right fit for their clients. Specifically, what form of and how much synchronous and/or asynchronous communication will be most effective for the fitness professional and client relationship, as well as intended goals and outcomes of the program.

Synchronous communication occurs at the same time (or *of the moment*) between more than one individual. An example of virtual synchronous communication would be a live video training session with a fitness professional (**Figure: Synchronous Communication Example**). The client, in this instance, would be receiving live (or *of the moment*) cues about how to move or adjust their form or rep counts and how to best proceed to the next exercise.



FigureSynchronous Communication Example

Synchronous communication is closest to the traditional personal training environment. If live video streams are used between a client and their fitness professional, many of the same benefits of in-person training can exist. Fitness professionals can comment immediately and directly and clients can pose questions about their program in real-time. Clients can also see the body language and physical responses of their fitness professional. Smiling, eye contact, and gestures can all relay enthusiasm and encouragement for positive reinforcement. Communication platforms that are synchronous include video calls and video conferencing and the phone.

Asynchronous communication is communication that occurs on delay (or *at a later time*) between more than one individual. E-mail is one form of asynchronous communication. For example, a fitness professional sends an instructional email to a client for that week's exercise program and then the client responds back at a later time with questions or comments (**Figure: Asynchronous Communication Example**). Other communication platforms that are asynchronous include online communities, certain apps, and texting.



FigureAsynchronous Communication Example
Synchronous communication

Communication occurring at the same time (or of the moment) between more than one individual.

Asynchronous communication

Communication occurring on a delay (or at a later time) between more than one individual.

When to Use Which Communication Method

Beyond understanding the concepts of asynchronous and synchronous communication is learning when to make the best use of each. Both forms of communications have advantages and disadvantages. The style of communication and when it is used is a skill as much as training itself. For example, too many reminders or interrupting messages from apps or online communities can end up creating a haze or ignoring effect (Kushlev et al., 2016). However, if a client needs time-sensitive assistance, they may benefit more from synchronous communication. For example, if a client needs multiple answers on how to handle a nutritional strategy problem, it might benefit both the fitness professional and client timewise to opt for a quick phone call and have a back-and-forth conversation.

Creating office hours and boundaries for synchronous communication is important for both the fitness professional and the client. Mobile app messaging, for example, can be a form of both asynchronous and synchronous communication, depending on the parameters. In some instances, the messaging is set during predetermined hours and a client can receive instant messaging or communication from the fitness professional. For example, if a client is in the middle of a training session and does not understand what level of fatigue in training they should achieve during their exercise sets, they can instant message their fitness professional and receive an immediate answer.

Other texting and messaging can be asynchronous, such as reminders or encouragements sent on schedules or not in real-time. Clients can find these messages useful, but a fitness professional needs to be careful to not constantly send reminders, updates, and messages to their client if the trigger effect is not needed. If a fitness professional does not respect the client's boundaries, it could lead to the client consciously or subconsciously viewing the messages as ineffective or irrelevant. These clients would need less-frequent and more specifically targeted, asynchronous communication, such as email.

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Fitness professionals should develop a system that works specifically for their targeted and continuous communication style and should ask themselves if they are someone who enjoys constant and instant interaction or less-frequent interaction. For example, some fitness professionals feed off the energy clients give them and need daily and consistent visual interaction. Such professionals would likely benefit from daily online classes or video conferencing with their clients. To the contrary, some fitness professionals may be more introverted and less comfortable with daily verbal or video conferencing communication and may enjoy less-frequent asynchronous interactions with their clients.

Additionally, one should determine the frequency and style of the client's check-ins. Fitness professionals need to have a consistent and predictable system in place that covers when the client checks in, how frequently, and which communication platform they use. Fitness professionals can use the exact same system and applications for all clients or vary them based on the various types of clients they work with.

There are a wide variety of communication forms and methods available for fitness professionals and clients to use. The type of platform used, the frequency, or how many of each platform used will vary based on the specific client and the programs and services being offered. Determining which platform is best for a given client can be achieved through gaining an understanding of the client's preferences, needs, and available resources. Is there a client who is overwhelmed by technology but is comfortable with email? Perhaps their preferred style of training is best suited to a particular app where everything is stored and accessible in one place. As the traditional fitness professional develops as a virtual coach, make note and keep a collection of which communication styles and platforms work best for given programs, scenarios, and client-types in order to put the client in the best position to achieve results.

Helpful Hint

Using a format that is convenient and comfortable for the fitness professional is just as important as one that is convenient and comfortable for the client.

Communicating Online: Asking Questions

Once the fitness professional determines which communication type and platforms they will be using, the next crucial phase is understanding *how* to communicate with potential clients. Assuming clients have gone through the qualifying process and ultimately signed on to work with a fitness professional or company, the next interactions with a client are the most important a fitness professional can have. The manner in which fitness professionals talk to clients, how they ask and respond to questions, and the plans they make for the future together pave the road for their relationship.

Collecting Client Information: Open-Ended and Closed-Ended Questions

Communicating virtually requires fitness professionals to effectively collect the information needed from the client to guide them in their journey while simultaneously using a client-centered approach and fostering personal autonomy. An effective way of achieving this is to allow the client to speak for themselves by using the right style of interviewing to evoke detailed and thoughtful responses. This style of interviewing revolves around open-ended questions.

Open-ended questions are questions worded in a manner that evokes thoughtfulness and reflection in the individual who is being asked. They cannot be answered by a simple “yes” or “no” response. These types of questions can help clients to explore deeper into their desires, goals, and emotional positions, while helping fitness professionals find out what motivates them and where their values lie and further understand their thought processes.

Most often, open-ended questions begin with “Why,” “What,” “How,” or “Tell me” and allow the client to speak freely. For example, **“Why are you looking to start an exercise program at this time?**

Using open-ended questions in interviews and interactions can help fitness professionals better understand their client’s motives, goals, and potential obstacles, which can help them find unique solutions to various circumstances. Often, this can lead to the client finding answers on their own by giving them the chance to voice their thoughts and connect different experiences together. Additionally, open-ended questions encourage the client to elaborate and give more nuanced explanations. At first, certain details may not seem relevant or important, but these can be the very details fitness professionals need most in order to tailor a program for success.

Open-ended questions

Questions worded in a manner that evokes thoughtfulness and reflection in the individual who is being asked.

Despite their many benefits, caution should be used with open-ended questions. They can and often do move into deeper personal spaces. It is pertinent to remain within the scope of the fitness professional and refer out to other appropriate providers when necessary.

Fitness professionals should seek permission with moving forward, and, when given, move slowly. Professionals should not rush the client or make them feel that any particular response is needed or that lack of response is brought with disappointment. **Figure: Seek Permission** is an example of appropriate dialogue:

Helpful Hint

Remember, open means it can *go anywhere* and closed is *locked* in place.



FigureSeek Permission

This example can be used in written or verbal form. Notice the professional is asking permission, providing the client with power, and allowing them to choose their own pace in responding. Fitness professionals should also keep in mind that the ability and benefits of seeing body language and hearing vocal inflection are lacking with written and certain virtual platforms. Written questions need to be carefully worded to ensure the tone is conveying an articulate message that is taken as intended. Framing things in an inclusive manner such as “we” or “us” can make the difference when delivering sensitive critique by reminding them it’s a team effort and that comments are not being made in judgement but rather in support. When communicating these messages vocally, fitness professionals should make sure to add reassuring phrases and check in on their client’s comfort while discussing potentially sensitive subjects.

Closed-ended questions are questions that are worded in a way that does not give opportunity to elaborate and typically can only be answered in a distinct and predetermined way. They leave no room for ambivalence or uncertainty and are most often used to ask permission or to obtain quantitative data. Some examples are **“Are you comfortable taking daily body weight?”** or **“Can you please fill out this weekly check-in form?”** or **“Do you mind if we discuss this further?”**

Closed-ended questions are questions with a “Yes” or “No” answer, and, although they are limiting in nature, they are sometimes required and can be very helpful. They are less explorative and more about finding specific answers to specific questions. They typically begin with, “Have you,” “Do you,” “Will you,” “Are you,” “Can you,” “Is it,” etc.

For the most part, open-ended questions should be the primary interviewing tool fitness professionals use with potential or current clients. Refer to **Table: Examples of Open and Closed-Ended Questions** for a list of examples of open- and closed-ended questions.

Examples of Open and Closed-Ended Questions

Open-Ended Questions	Closed-Ended Questions
What are your current goals?	Do you feel comfortable sharing measurements and data?
What are you looking to achieve with training?	Will you have 30 minutes each day to exercise?
What are your exercise experiences?	Do you have access to a gym?
Tell me what you know about nutrition intake?	Is it okay if I ask you questions about your nutrition?
What are specific things you want to achieve in the next year?	Is it okay if I ask you questions about your physical history?
What do you feel are some of your strengths?	Do you have adequate time to focus on these goals right now?

Closed-ended questions

Questions worded in a way that does not give opportunity to elaborate and typically can only be answered in a distinct and predetermined way.

Virtual Goal Setting

Once the fitness professional has asked open- and closed-ended questions in order to build rapport with the client, the next step is to set goals for their program using a framework or system like **SMART goals**. In the questionnaire or consultation process, a fitness professional should ask the client what their current short-term and long-term goals are, what they want to achieve, and by when they want to achieve it. From there, using SMART as a guideline, the fitness professional will have the ability to work with the client and determine the pace and appropriate method for achieving those goals.

SMART Goals

Goals are actions or results an individual wants to achieve, generally within a specified timeframe. Fitness professionals will encounter clients who have a variety of goals ranging from increasing strength, daily mobility, muscle growth, and cardiovascular improvements. Each client will have different goals and different timelines and expectations for their goals. One of the roles of a fitness professional is to be the manager and facilitator of their client's goals. One way a fitness professional can do this is by following a researched and tested formula of goal setting called SMART goals. **SMART** is an acronym that stands for **S**pecific, **M**easurable, **A**chievable, **R**elevant, and **T**ime-bound. The concept of SMART originated in the 1950s in management and company improvement research (Day & Tosey, 2011). Since that time, SMART goals have been found useful as a framework for a wide variety of goal setting circumstances.

SMART Goals - Definition and Examples

Defining a SMART Goal	Application
Specific Is the goal specific?	The goal should not be vague or unclear. It should be targeted, purposeful, and specific in nature. The more narrowed the focus on the goal, the more likely the things needed to be done to achieve the goal will be as well. Example of a non-specific goal: *I want to exercise more.* Example of a specific goal: *I will follow a strength building program and exercise 4 days every week.*

Measurable How will the goal be measured?	The goal should have metrics and references of measure. The fitness professional should be able to trend and study the progress of the client's success toward their goal. Example of non-measured goal: *The client updates you every few weeks saying they have completed (and sometimes not completed) their goals with very little charting or records.* Example of a measured goal: *Once a week, the client updates a premade form covering the exercise, reps, sets, and intensity required to gauge their program results and direct any changes.*
Achievable Is the goal one that can be completed?	The goal should be achievable. It should be technically possible to accomplish. Example of non-achievable goal: *A middle-aged client wants a training program to increase their height by 5 inches.* Example of an achievable goal: *A middle-aged client wants a training program to help improve their standing posture.*
Relevant Is the goal realistically achievable for that person? Is the goal personally meaningful?	While similar to an attainable goal, this goal needs to be relevant and realistically possible for the specific client. Simply because a goal is technically attainable does not mean the goal itself is realistic for that particular individual. Example of non-realistic goal: *A client wants to lose 20 lbs of pure fat in 1 month.* Example of an achievable goal: *A client wants to lose 2 lbs of pure fat in 1 month.*
Time-Bound Is there a definite timeline for completion of the goal?	The goal should have a start date and a termination date. If multiple goals are being selected, each of them should move in unison with the other and have time-specific dates for reassessment. Example of non-time-bound goal: *A client wants to gain muscle at some point.* Example of a time-bound goal: *A client wants to gain 2 lbs of muscle in a 3-month time period.*

SMART goals

An acronym that stands for specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound goals.

Outcome and Process Goals

An **outcome goal** is defined as the target or definitive end point of the set goal. For example, if the goal is to gain 2 pounds of muscle by the client's birthday, that is the outcome. Outcome goals are also synonymous with concepts like short-term and long-term goals.

A **process goal** is the method or alteration of habit used to achieve that goal. For example, to gain 2 pounds of muscle by their birthday, the client will need to take part in a nutrition and specific exercise training program to support that outcome.

In process goals, there can also be performance goals. **Performance goals** are defined by setting a new achievement(s) within the performance being measured. For example, if the process goal is to perform three sets of 10 deadlifts in the workout, the performance goal could be to track the ability to increase weight when doing a deadlift.

Generally speaking, time is typically best spent working on process goals. While it is important to have a larger focus on the end direction or outcome, the short-term process completion can help a client build momentum and self-efficacy toward achieving continued success with their goals. Research suggests that short-term goals can be defined as any goal attempted to be completed in less than 12 months (Ogbeiwi, 2017). Most literature agrees that 3 months is a good starting point for short-term goal achievement; however, individuals can focus efforts of smaller periods of time and interweave process goals alongside their outcome goals. For example, it can be more rewarding to an individual to set a process goal of training 4 days each week as they work toward achieving their 3-month goal. Each training session completed is another notch toward completion of the overall process and achievement of the goal.

Outcome goal

A goal defined as the target or definitive end point of the set goal.

Process goal

A goal defined as the method or alteration of habits used to achieve that goal.

Performance goals

A goal defined by setting a new achievement within the performance being measured.

In the end, when looking at goal completion, key takeaways are ensuring goal output is achievable and supplies momentum to the client. One of the primary underlying themes of the SMART goals framework is to leverage accomplishment of smaller, realistic goals to ultimately achieve success.

Collecting client information and goal setting is critical in making a great first impression. The fitness professional will do this with a series of questions during assessment and then follow-up with back-and-forth dialogue until the outcome and process goals are established. The manner in which a fitness professional speaks with their client during this process will set the tone for the rest of their relationship. Here is an example (**Figure: Setting the Tone**):



FigureSetting the Tone

The client should feel comfortable with the questions being asked, feel they are able to speak freely and provide their own input and desires, and should never feel uneasy during the consultation experience. The client should be in charge of their own goals at all times during this process and the goals should be of their choosing. The client should have autonomy and feel in control of their future with an increasing sense of confidence in their ability to succeed. Goals should be specific and targeted, yet realistically achievable, and have the ability to be measured. They should, ultimately, be realistic and achievable. Ultimately, a fitness professional's job is to foster client self-confidence as they help guide them toward achievement of their goals.

Virtual Accountability and Check-Ins

Accountability is being held responsible to an organization or another individual to achieve a desired outcome. Fitness professionals are the accountability agent for their clients. Due to the transactional nature of the relationship, fitness professionals are there to not only provide educated and carefully considered programming, they are also there to help the client achieve execution of the programming and outcomes. In the beginning, a fitness professional will collect and gather their client's information during a data collection phase. Then, together with the client, they will each determine outcome goals. After that, the client will progress to completing their goals with the fitness professional there for support and accountability throughout the process.



FigureCycle of Accountability
Accountability

Being held responsible to an organization or another individual to achieve a desired outcome.

Measures of Accountability and Data Collection

The fitness professional and the client should come together on their ideal accountability parameters. There should be enough data collection to allow the fitness professional to have an educated understanding of the client's progress toward their goals, but not so much information that the client is uncomfortable, it becomes unmanageable, or it is un-actionable. Autonomy in the check-in and data collection process is crucial to building a long-term relationship with the client. For example, some clients may find themselves negatively stimulated by daily weigh-ins while other clients find it motivating. This may also change through the course of working with the client and may need to be adjusted along the way. Clients should look forward to the weekly process of goal competition and data-collection. They should not have negative emotions attached to the process; otherwise, it is likely that compliance and dedication will wane.

Once the parameters have been established, a fitness professional needs to have some form of data collection available in order to track client progress. Fitness professionals can use applications in which the client inputs the data on their side and the fitness professional has visibility to see it, or they can receive the data from the client and input it themselves. Budget and technology capabilities will determine applications used. For example, Google Sheets™ is a spreadsheet application that is free with a Google account and allows both the fitness professional and the client to review, edit, and update the same document.

When a fitness professional has selected the best platform for communication and data collection and the client understands the purpose of each when working together, the next step is to actually start collecting data. In fact, data collection starts the moment a fitness professional begins interacting with a client. Every aspect of a fitness professional's working relationship with clients involves important information that can be used to help clients achieve their goals. Fitness professionals learn most of this when initially evaluating and assessing their client; however, a certain amount of that information will need to be carried over from week-to-week in order to measure results and progress.

Physical Data

Physical data is comprised of an individual's current makeup, such as age and anthropometric measurements like height, weight, body circumference, and body fat percentage. Depending on the client's goals, these physical data measurements may be essential to tracking their progress toward physical goals.

Pictures can also be used to track physical data and for pre- or post-comparison photos. This is especially useful for clients who want to achieve changes in body composition, like fat loss or muscle gain, in which the scale or other measurements may not give the clearest or most accurate indication of progress toward the goal. However, remember, not all clients are comfortable sharing photos. It is incredibly important to provide a safe as well as secure space for clients to provide and store their progress photos.

Physical data

Data comprised of an individual’s current makeup, such as age, height, weight, and measurements, including inches and body-fat percentage.

The following is an example of how collecting the combination of weight and physical data can help troubleshoot what seems like a fat-loss plateau (**Figure: Troubleshooting Physical Data)**. Remember, this conversation can happen through email or video conferencing. Be mindful of tone and execution in conversation. Without physical data, a client could likely become discouraged and may veer off the course set for them to achieve their goals. Fitness professionals should always use the data to encourage clients and highlight successful efforts.



FigureTroubleshooting Physical Data

Performance Data

Performance data includes alterations in any marker in which improvement or maintenance is looking to be achieved. Heart rate, for example, can be a great indicator of improved cardiovascular health in clients. Decreases in resting heart rate over time or alterations in heart rate variability (HRV) can be a sign of improved overall health (Kim et al., 2018). One-repetition maximum (1RM) testing (or other variants of repetition maximum testing), as well as some of the other objective assessments highlighted in the assessments chapter, are other reliable indicators of performance improvement (Levinger et al., 2009). By consistently collecting and tracking this data, even from a distance, fitness professionals can continue to monitor and track progress and guide their client in the pursuit and achievement of their goals.

Most performance data, as related to the previous examples, is fairly straightforward to collect, monitor, and track:

- Did the client lift heavier weights for a given exercise? Did they achieve more volume in their program?
- Has the client's resting heart rate decreased over time? Has their HRV increased over time?
- Did their muscular endurance increase?
- Did they run farther, faster, or both?

These objective physical indicators of performance are generally easy to relay, read, and track over time.

Another performance parameter that can be used to measure progress is compliance ratings. Compliance ratings are how well a client felt they did in achieving that day's process or goal. If a client has a goal of training 4 days a week, fitness professionals can provide them with a yes–no response section in their check-in. If they have achieved four "Yes" responses to the question "Did you train today?" then they have achieved a week of compliance.

Performance data

Data including alterations in any marker in which improvement or maintenance is looking to be achieved.

Compliance ratings can be helpful to see overall trends in performance and for troubleshooting changes in or lack of progress. If there is a challenge improving in particular physical performance parameters or goal-achievement, the first place to look is compliance. If a client is not gaining in strength at a rate they desire but is not hitting their compliance rating, fitness professionals can help explain their lack of results as a possibility of missed sessions. Here is a conversational example (**Figure: Discussing Results**) where the fitness professional could be discussing their results via a video conferencing call:



FigureDiscussing Results

This fitness professional could schedule an additional video conference call to help the client maintain compliance during that following week. Compliance ratings are not about judging the client; they are about using the data to determine if that is contributing to the observed issue or concerns shared by the client. The same approach can be used for clients who tend to put in too much work (**Figure: Discussing Compliance Data**).



FigureDiscussing Compliance Data

Success toward any goal is about maintaining the balance in the work-to-rest ratio. The data fitness professionals regularly collect from clients helps determine if that balance is on or off target.

Lifestyle Data

Lifestyle data is made up of variables that can affect the success of outcome and process goals. For example, a client who is attempting to lose body fat and/or regulate their food intake may struggle in their ability to comply with their program goals due to consecutive nights of poor sleep (Landis et al., 2009). For athletes, inability to maintain adequate water intake throughout the day could decrease performance capabilities (Casa et al., 2019). These data markers can give clues and insight into potential program adjustments a fitness professional or client can make or areas where they might benefit from some additional focus.

Lifestyle data is also important in helping identify and empathize with struggles and difficulties clients face. If a client is reporting excessive fatigue, work stress, and poor sleep, it may become clear to the fitness professional that achieving established goals may be difficult and may not necessarily be the top priority for the client at the present time. It is the fitness professional's responsibility to evaluate the data and the client's status and to work with them to modify or adjust program priorities—and possibly goals—to reflect their current situation. A strategy to implement this using data would be scale ratings. For example, clients can be asked to rate how much fatigue or stress they feel on a scale of 1-10, 10 being the most fatigued or stressed and 1 being the least.

Lifestyle data

Data made up of variables that can affect the success of outcome and process goals.

It is not uncommon for clients to experience challenges along the way to improved health, fitness, and performance. Fitness professionals should strive to help clients work through both good and tough times as a part of their support system. Here is an example of using lifestyle data during an email check-in with a client who is struggling to maintain consistency with their training (**Figure: Lifestyle Data**):



FigureLifestyle Data
Critical!

A fitness professional's role is never to judge or criticize the pace of a client's progression. It is up to the client to determine the speed at which they want to move forward.

Client Comments

When working with a client, fitness professionals should provide a space for comments outside of data collection. Comments are critical in communication between a fitness professional and their client. There are many times clients may have information or comments about their day or week that may not fit perfectly into a particular column or category within a data collection survey. Sometimes, a client simply needs to vent and discuss their feelings about the week or make additional comments regarding their training sessions. These conversations can often offer insight into potential roadblocks that may impact their training or nutrition as well as building further trust in the working relationship.

Commentary should always be encouraged, and it is often beneficial to query further when opportunities arise. It is a fitness professional's responsibility to ask questions if there is something in a client program that needs addressing. Here is an example of encouraging a client to comment, if desired, while respecting their boundaries (**Figure: Encouraging a Client to Comment**):



FigureEncouraging a Client to Comment

Note, it is not a fitness professional's place to dictate to a client; however, if the client has set a goal and asked for accountability for that goal, it is okay to engage and ask them questions regarding their actions if they do not match up to what they committed to (**Table: Examples of Accountability Data to Collect**).

Examples of Accountability Data to Collect

Physical	**Performance**	**Lifestyle**	**Comments**
Age	Heart Rate	Sleep Hygiene (Quality and/or Quantity)	
Height	HRV	Hydration	
Weight	Strength Increases	Fatigue Score	
Circumference Measurements	Volume (Reps/Sets) Increases	Mediation	
Body Fat %	ROM/Mobility Improvement	Supplement Tracking	(Provide a space for clients to provide general comments.)
	Jump Measures (Height, Distance, Repetitions, etc.) Increase	Alcohol/Drug Use	
Progress Pictures	Balance Measures Improvements		
	Running Metrics (Distance, Time, Pace, etc.)	Stress Score	
	Compliance Ratings		

Client Check-In Questions and Data Collection

Depending on the system a fitness professional uses and the programs and services offered, the client can check-in with them daily, weekly, or monthly. The process should be simple and easy for the client to complete. The client should have a sheet, form, or application to fill out the selected, predetermined criteria based on their goals. The client should have a clear understanding before going into a check-in what data they are expected to provide, the date and time it needs to be provided by, and what protocol to follow if they are unable to complete their check-ins on time. With the right check-in structure, documentation, and system, clients should find the technical aspect of checking-in relatively simple and easy.

The fitness professional should select and provide a form or questionnaire for their client to complete during the check-in process. Always remember, the amount and type of data and process to collect it should only be as intensive and involved as the client needs it to be in order to accomplish their goals—nothing more. Fitness professionals should take care and caution not to overwhelm clients with too much information or too complicated a process to collect it. Often, less is more.

Here is an example of a spreadsheet structure for a client who is looking to alter body composition and train four times a week (**Table: Spreadsheet Structure for Altering Body Composition**).

Spreadsheet Structure for Altering Body Composition

Date	Training Session	A.M. Weight	Caloric Intake Estimate	Protein	Carbs	Fat	Sleep	Water Intake	Fatigue Score 1–10

Data reporting specific to training is generally best done in a separate spreadsheet from the compliance and physical data forms. Clients should be encouraged to track their training session data if they are serious about goal and performance progression.

Table: Spreadsheet Structure for Training Session Tracking is an example of a spreadsheet structure for training session and progression tracking.

Spreadsheet Structure for Training Session Tracking

Date:	**Fatigue Score:**		**Sleep:**
Exercise Description	**Reps Sets Intensity/Load**	**Rest Time**	**Notes/Comments**

Fitness professionals should not only provide a structure for clients to record their exercise movements, but also a place to comment or relay notes regarding how the movements felt, if they were having an off day, or if an exercise did not feel right or good. If a client repeatedly experiences and shares a particular problem with a certain exercise, that should prompt the fitness professional to modify the movement or exercise or change it altogether. It is also important to take note of a client's fatigue score or sleep *prior* to training to see if other factors are influencing their training session experience and results.

Before the Check-In

Communication and organization are important elements for fitness professionals to maximize success in helping clients achieve their goals. As previously discussed, the rapport and manner in which a fitness professional speaks to their client is critical to fostering the relationship and building trust. Moreover, staying organized and incorporating good data collection habits into the routine will allow fitness professionals to identify trends, positive or negative, in order to best assist and serve their client.

On receipt of the first check-in, the fitness professional should already have a process and structure in place to keep clients' data organized and easily accessible for review. Even if client data is stored in an application or software system, fitness professionals should take the extra step and establish best practices for keeping their own records, notes, and thoughts for each client. While this may seem redundant, excessive, or too clinical, it allows the fitness professional to troubleshoot problems almost instantly as they arise, encourage the client when needed, and offer protection from liability, should something unfortunate occur.

For example, not all data can be simply categorized. There are times when clients are simply human, experiencing certain emotions that need to be noted. This is especially true if a fitness professional is working with a higher volume of clients. Relying on memory alone or raw data without context can allow for gaps, which may limit or undermine the effectiveness of the fitness professional's rapport with a client. Fitness professionals should have their own notes, reminders, and comments regarding their clients saved and stored somewhere secure, even if they are relying on an external or app-driven system.

Mindset During the Check-In

The fitness professional's role is not to determine, dictate, or judge client goals, but rather to help their client achieve the goals they desire while respecting their boundaries. Fitness professionals often tend to take the results and success of their clients personally; nothing could do more to harm the relationship between them. It is vital to recognize that a client's goals and wishes are separate from those of a fitness professional. Fitness professionals should always resist the urge or desire to put any of their own wishes, desires, or expectations onto the client.

The check-in process should be a positive experience for the client every time. They should feel free to ask questions without worry or ridicule. They should also never be afraid or anxious to report results, regardless of how close (or far) they are from achieving their goals.

Feedback to Client

When a fitness professional receives their check-in from the client, he/she should have notes or spreadsheet systems open and ready to document thoughts or important markers of interest during the check-in. Fitness professionals should then review the answers and data in response to the predetermined questions and begin to organize and arrange their comments.

Table: Example of Client Looking to Alter Body Composition is an example of a completed spreadsheet from a client looking to alter their body composition through losing fat and maintaining muscle by training 4 times a week.

Example of Client Looking to Alter Body Composition

Date	Training Session	A.M. Weight	Caloric Intake	Protein	Carbs	Fat	Sleep	Water Intake	Fatigue Score 1–10
8/06	Yes	65 kgs	2000	140 g	250 g	75 g	7.5 hrs	70 oz	2
8/07	No	64.4 kgs	2000	180 g	195 g	55 g	7.0 hrs	70 oz	2
8/08	Yes	64.8 kgs	2000	160 g	190 g	68 g	6.5 hrs	70 oz	4
8/09	No	64.8 kgs	2500	120 g	300 g	90 g	7.5 hrs	70 oz	3
8/10	No	65.6 kgs	?	?	?	?	6.0 hrs	?	6
8/11	No	65.4 kgs	3000	160 g	?	?	8.5 hrs	70 oz	5
8/12	No	66.4 kgs	?	?	?	?	7.5 hrs	?	3

Without any other comments from the client, a fitness professional should be able to look at the data to determine possible questions to ask and topics to discuss with their client (**Table: Determining Questions to Ask and Topics to Discuss**).

Determining Questions to Ask and Topics to Discuss

Date	Training Session	A.M. Weight	Caloric Intake	Protein	Carbs	Fat	Sleep	Water Intake	Fatigue Score 1–10
8/06	Yes	65 kgs	2200	140 g	250 g	75 g	7.5 hrs	70 oz	2
8/07	No	64.4 kgs	2000	180 g	195 g	55 g	7.0 hrs	70 oz	2
8/08	Yes	64.8 kgs	2000	160 g	190 g	68 g	5.5 hrs	70 oz	4
8/09	No	64.8 kgs	2500	120 g	300 g	90 g	7.5 hrs	70 oz	3
8/10	No	65.6 kgs	?	?	?	?	6.0 hrs	?	6
8/11	No	65.4 kgs	3000	160 g	?	?	8.5 hrs	70 oz	5
8/12	No	66.4 kgs	?	?	?	?	7.5 hrs	?	3

Based on the highlighted data in the spreadsheet (**Table: Determining Questions to Ask and Topics to Discuss**) the fitness professional should consider the following:

- Ask their client the reason for lack of training toward the end of the week.
- Make a note that body weight has trended upward toward the end of the week.
- Discuss possible setbacks toward achieving outcome results from a lack of tracking data.
- Ask their client about their inconsistent sleep and if good sleep hygiene is being practiced. Or perhaps send them some literature on the topic to enhance their understanding of how important sleep quality and consistency is to achieving their goals.

Next, fitness professionals should look at any comments or notes left by the client. In this example, the client included the following feedback and comments (**Figure: Client Comments**).



FigureClient Comments

Fitness professionals should use the client's feedback and comments as well as all the data to form an articulate and helpful response. Between the client feedback and spreadsheet data, focus on as many of the positive attributes as possible when formulating the response (**Figure: Fitness Professional Response**).



FigureFitness Professional Response

The feedback from the fitness professional is littered with tips and pointers on client etiquette. The following in **Table: Analyzing Fitness Professional Feedback** are a few selected quotes and comments about the written approach.

Analyzing Fitness Professional Feedback

Quotes	Comments
Based on your comments, I could sense you were not very happy with your check-in this week. To me, the most encouraging part was you writing "I'll try better next week."	One should always strive to find the most positive attributes in the client's comments. In this instance, the client expressed desire to want to do better. Fitness professionals should always start an email on a clear and positive note.
It's always hard to say exactly what helps or hinders achieving a goal, but we do know from research a lack of sleep can change hunger levels—leading to overeating of high-calorie, low-nutrient foods. By the way, if you'd like to see some of that research, feel free to ask.	Fitness professionals should do the best they can to stay up-to-date on current research to be better able to answer clients' questions. Clients do not always want to read the research themselves and that is okay. However, fitness professionals should be willing and able to back up their programs, strategies, feedback, and suggestions with research that supports them.
Again, it's typical and normal, but if you know or are aware you do it, you can practice more mindfulness to avoid it if the situation comes up again.	Clients can often feel alone and nervous when trying to achieve their goals. Discourage feelings of failure and inadequacy.
Keep up the effort and don't let this week discourage you!	Fitness professionals should strive to keep an energetic and upbeat disposition and always end their communication on an encouraging, positive note.

Ultimately, accountability is about being a source of assistance to the client both in education and consistency. The role of a fitness professional is to help clients achieve their goals by collecting and analyzing data and then leveraging it to assist and guide them through the process of change. Professionals should select the type and amount of data they need based on the client's individual goals and circumstances—taking care not to overwhelm clients with unnecessary requirements or data tracking.

Additionally, fitness professionals should have an organized and consistent process and system of data collection. When collecting and analyzing data, fitness professionals should organize their thoughts and take relevant notes so they can prepare and communicate constructive feedback to help their client.

Lastly, fitness professionals should remain neutral and be present in the client's goals alongside them. They should always be prepared for shifts in goals or altered outcomes. At no time should a fitness professional feel personally affected or attached to the specific goals or outcomes a client seeks to achieve.

Communicating Online: Building Rapport

Every interaction a fitness professional has with a client is a chance to strengthen or to weaken the relationship if they are not sensitive and thoughtful with their communication. To strengthen relationships, fitness professionals use rapport. **Rapport** is a relationship built on an agreement of mutual respect and understanding of the respective roles and empathy that allows for clear and effective communication. Building rapport is an ongoing process of active listening, shared experiences, and empathy. Rapport is practically impossible to build or establish under disingenuous circumstances. Choosing to care about clients is an investment worth putting time and effort into and can result in a gratifying career and an emotionally fulfilled client roster.

For success, patience and consideration is needed equally by both parties. Taking time to communicate with consideration and thought rather than rushing the process is likely to produce happy clients who feel looked after and valued. Alternatively, snappy, short, or truncated responses, can result in clients who become closed off, ashamed to ask questions, or feel as though they are not cared for. The right delivery can help assure that even challenging messages and more difficult conversations are perceived respectfully. Clients should feel trust in the professional and that they have their best intentions at heart.

For example, if a fitness professional encounters a situation where they are unable to respond immediately to a client because they need to carefully construct their thoughts, any potential tension can be mitigated by being honest and telling the truth (**Figure: Thoughtful Response**).

Simply relaying a time frame for response reduces potential anxiety for a client. If a fitness professional can respond faster, great. However, the client knows not to be concerned or worried by a lack of response until 48 hours have passed. It can mean the difference between a client feeling like they are the only client, are cared for and thought of as an individual, rather than feeling like they are just another number in the business roster.



FigureThoughtful Response
Rapport

A relationship built on an agreement of mutual respect and understanding of the respective roles and empathy that allows for clear and effective communication.

Positive Affirmations

Affirmations are another important piece of the fitness coaching communication toolbox. An affirmation is a positive statement highlighting traits, characteristics, actions, behaviors, etc.

Ultimately, the fitness professional wants clients to recognize these in themselves, but at the start of the relationship, it may require the fitness professional to highlight them. Fitness professionals can help clients reflect on themselves and see not just what they want to improve but also what they currently do well. In time, the objective is for clients to begin to adopt this positive mindset, observe their own victories, and begin to exhibit more confidence and self-compassion. When these personal skills grow, it can improve a client's ability to move forward with consistency rather than being anchored in place by negative thinking.

Additionally, fitness professionals should balance constructive feedback with positive affirmations as much as possible, and clients should hopefully leave each interaction feeling better than before and as though they are on the right track. Fitness professionals should empower the client while decreasing negativity. Improving exercise and nutrition habits are staples in individuals who embark on a journey toward self-improvement. That journey should always come from a positive place. For example, many individuals who seek out weight-loss programs who are met with stark opposition and shaming will actually gain weight (Sutin & Terracciano, 2013). Research has consistently shown negative emotions hinder success for individuals looking to improve.

In practice, weekly check-ins are one of the most important places to use positive affirmations. Specifically, in the beginning of the fitness professional–client relationship, it is important to foster an unconditionally positive and supportive environment. These early stages help clients hear and realize the things they are doing right, building their confidence as well as strengthening the bond with their fitness professional. Fitness professionals need to promote an open and honest relationship in which the client is unafraid to share their struggles and stumbles because they know they will not be met with judgment or shame but, instead, guidance and understanding. Through the fitness professional’s continued positive affirmation, clients will often start to develop their own positive self-affirmations and observations, which will shape their future behaviors and decisions.

Affirmations

A positive statement highlighting traits, characteristics, actions, behaviors, etc.

Here is an example of a fitness professional using affirmations to reveal the positive actions taken by a client in a challenging situation (**Figure: Affirmations**).

In this explanation, one should see the goal is to encourage rather than discourage the client from attending social gatherings and avoiding “tasty” food. The fitness professional is framing social events as opportunities to learn and test new skills and also provides an opportunity to reflect further with an open-ended question at the end of the interaction. A fitness professional should help reduce fears and anxieties and encourage enjoyment, inclusivity, and, above all, autonomy in their clients. Were the fitness professional to shame this individual instead of using affirmation or to cast doubt in the client’s mind regarding their ability to attend such an event and make sound choices, then this could potentially reinforce the client’s fears and promote reclusiveness, anxiety, and shame—the opposite of what fitness professionals want to achieve with clients.

Poor affirmation building can also close off further communication with the fitness professional. Clients could become fearful of the fitness professional’s response in situations where they perceive to have performed poorly. It is not realistic for a fitness professional given their responsibility or role to expect perfection from a client. Through affirmation, fitness professionals have the potential to teach clients about learning points and opportunities, even within uncomfortable situations. Through self-reflection and a positive outlook, clients can derive valuable lessons from these situations and utilize them in the future to improve downstream outcomes.



FigureAffirmations

Empathetic Approach

Empathy is the ability to imagine oneself in the position of another and to relate to a person from this frame of reference while trying to understand why they think and feel the way they do when viewed from their standpoint and experiences.

The ability of a fitness professional to empathize with their client can have a profound effect on the client—fitness professional relationship. A client's perception of a fitness professional's empathy may be a better predictor of positive client outcomes than how knowledgeable the fitness professional is in their respective field (Watson et al., 2014). Empathy should be used selectively and with careful reserve.



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Professionals should not presume to know exactly what a client feels or has experienced, as it is impossible to truly experience life through anyone else's eyes. Through the cultivation of great interpersonal communication skills, reflection, and visualization, a fitness professional can try to piece together the life and experiences of their client.

Fitness professionals often attempt to draw on their own experiences, knowledge, and education to try and find solutions to the unique problems each client faces. Taking the time and care to try to understand a client from a more holistic point-of-view can help fitness professionals guide clients through their journey to improved health more effectively. It is true the most theoretically sound fitness and nutrition plan will be useless if it cannot be applied and executed by the individual for whom it was programmed. In this instance, the client is the confounding variable. The capacity for empathy coupled with the discerning ability to apply it and when can determine the spectrum of individuals with whom fitness professionals can achieve results.

Food for Thought

While it might seem relating to a client is the best thing to do, it is often better to simply listen.

Empathy

The ability to imagine oneself in the position of another and to relate to a person from this frame of reference while trying to understand why they think and feel the way they do when viewed from their standpoint and experiences.

A key component to being able to empathize with clients is the ability to remove biases. Professionals all have biases, and no matter how unbiased one believes themselves to be, situations will arise where personal beliefs and values will be an impediment. As practitioners, it is important to be as aware of pre-held bias as possible.

For example, say a fitness professional has a history of exercise disordered behavior. In their own experience, they used exercise in an unhealthy manner to control and attempt to solve problems. That fitness professional needs to be careful to not project their own tendencies onto their client. A client may enjoy a higher threshold of training, but, for them, it is not being expressed out of a negative circumstance. The fitness professional needs to critically evaluate their position and ensure they are not involving their own past experiences or misplacing empathy in the situation—constructing a problem where one does not actually exist. Professionals need to remember in all dealings with clients that it is not about their preferences, abilities, or values; it is about the client. It is about assessing the client's values, goals, and growth and helping them align their behaviors with their goals. This is a continually evolving process and one that requires frequent reassessment and reevaluation. Clients goals and desires are not static; over time, they may change, as can circumstances. As they do, so must the approach a fitness professional takes into the interaction.

Furthermore, an empathetic approach includes always keeping in mind that a client does not know the mind of the fitness professional. To assume they do is a disservice to them. Professionals are teachers of the specific skills for which they are hired. Clients do not have the professional's knowledge, so much patience is needed. Empathy from the fitness professional should be expressed from the place in which they were once the student of an unknown skill. Fitness professionals may have to reiterate the same information many times and in many ways before finding a method of communication that speaks to the individual.

Individuals do not assimilate and process information in the same way. The fitness professional must find a strategy to communicate with their client so that they understand, grow, and learn and always do so with respect and professionalism. Fitness professionals do not define where the client starts; they must work to understand where their client has been and take on the sum of their client's experiences up to the point the relationship begins—and let that define where things start.

Virtual Motivational Interviewing

Motivational interviewing is an empathetic, collaborative, and client-centered approach to communication. It is designed to help direct clients through ambivalence and support positive change. In these instances, ambivalence may be expressed in intermittent indifference to the client's own goals or changing of focus. Motivational interviewing helps shift the focus by asking questions in such a way as to evoke thoughtfulness and reflection from clients to help them find their own reasons for change and motivation, in a non-judgmental, compassionate manner.

Motivational interviewing has been found to be especially effective in helping clients achieve change through health and fitness (Armstrong et al., 2011) Virtual motivational interviewing is similar to the in-person experience. The greatest obstacle to overcome in virtual communications is the preservation of clarity and tone in translation. The manner in which professionals speak in-person may not always transfer to the written word, and, without the benefit of non-verbal cues, interactions need to be more conscientiously crafted. When creating any response, careful consideration should be taken to how it will be interpreted and received. Prior to sending, fitness professionals should reread responses to ensure they are concise, professional, relevant, empathetic, and compassionate. It may take extra time to do so, but those details can create a vastly different experience for both the client and the fitness professional and, often, can lead to a more meaningful, successful, and longer-term working relationship.

Motivational interviewing

An empathetic, collaborative, and client-centered approach to communication designed to help counsel clients through ambivalence and support positive change.

Behavioral Change

Changing behaviors is difficult. Many barriers to change exist in both physical and mental paths. All individuals have their own composition of fear, education, environment, social settings, and time constraints that create different outcomes and building blocks for the same problems. To help clients find what approach will work for them, fitness professionals first need to help them find the root of these issues so the proper maps can be created to alter the course and path of their future. As presented by the Stages of Change Model or Transtheoretical Model of Change (**Figure: Stages of Change**), developed in the 1970's by Prochaska and DiClemente, there are five stages of change:



FigureStages of Change

- **Precontemplation** – At this stage, an individual is not yet aware or is unwilling to accept that a change is needed. They are likely hanging on to their current behaviors and have not yet found intrinsic motivation to change but may have pressure from other sources to make change.
- **Contemplation** – The client has started to become aware that a change is needed, but they are struggling with the pros and cons of doing so, the amount of effort that may be required of them, or what they may have to sacrifice to see change.
- **Preparation** – This is the stage where serious consideration starts to take place and even a desire to begin taking steps to make change. At this point, they are starting to think about what they can do to bring about change but may still be struggling with knowing where to begin. The desire for change is there.
- **Action** – Here they start taking physical action, moving beyond the stages of mental effort to actually taking steps to implement the changes that, until this point, have only been considerations. For many, this will be the most difficult stage as it is the "first step," so to speak, and where they will have to put forth the greatest commitment to keep momentum.
- **Maintenance** – At this point, the client has been consistent with their new behaviors for at least 6 months (Rubak et al., 2005) and it is becoming an integrated part of their lifestyle. Getting here does not mean they will stay here, though, and, if they have not been focused on a sustainable approach, they are still at risk of relapse to old behaviors.

In reality, individuals will often shift back and forth between various stages of change as they encounter new obstacles or things in their lives change, and, although they can progress through the stages in a linear fashion, that may not be typical.

Client Ambivalence

It is also common throughout the coaching process to encounter client ambivalence, where the client has reservations about certain changes, which will vary in reason from person to person. **Ambivalence** is a state of mind where an individual may have conflict, disinterest, or resistance regarding an outcome or individual.

For example, ambivalence can present, at times, revolving around nutrition where the client is overwhelmed at the notion of learning to eat by hunger cues or perhaps eating at set mealtimes. Altering habits are not easy and resistance is part of change. In another example, if a client wants to participate in a specific training program but cannot due to time constraints, their enthusiasm may decrease while ambivalence increases because their “perfect” schedule cannot be achieved. If they have the perception they are unable to get results on one program, they may choose to do no program at all.

Often, a major point of friction and cause for ambivalence from clients comes from the desire to see results while maintaining their current lifestyles. Individuals want fast results, change, and instant fixes rather than the uncomfortable process of self-evaluation and exploration. It can be difficult for them to accept their current state due to past and current choices, beliefs, and behaviors. Acceptance can be overwhelming at times, but it is imperative to achieve long-term change. By altering and redirecting focus, the client may get to a place they might not have reached previously.

Ambivalence

A state of mind in which an individual may have conflict, disinterest, or resistance regarding an outcome or individual.

Change Talk Versus Sustain Talk

Change talk is language that supports behavior change. As much as possible, fitness professionals want to promote change talk with their clients (Apodaca et al., 2016). Fitness professionals should encourage client autonomy while staying true to their core values and facilitating positive changes to assist them in reaching their goals. An example of change talk may sound like this (**Figure: Change Talk**):

Try This

Whenever a client expresses negatives, fitness professionals should do what they can to find the positives.



FigureChange Talk

Here the client is giving a smoke signal call of change and the underlying theme is achievement.

Change talk

Language that supports behavior change.

Conversely, researchers also discuss **sustain talk**. Sustain talk is any language that is in support of avoiding change. This style of talk often signals, consciously or not, a desire to resist change and keep to previous or current paths, which do not put the individual on course for their goals. Sustain talk may sound like this (**Figure: Sustain Talk**):



FigureSustain Talk
Change Talk Versus Sustain Talk

Change Talk	Sustain Talk
I'm struggling with finding the perfect balance, but I know it's something I'll do.	Maybe this isn't for me?
I get tired and this is hard, but I think this is worth doing.	I've accepted I'm not young anymore and I have to let go of a lot of dreams.
I guess learning new things is part of this process, right?	I just want to live a normal life again!
There are moments of sacrifice, but I know the results are worth it.	I'm not sure why I'm even doing this.

Both styles of talk may come up as professionals try to help clients through ambivalence. There are times clients find difficulty letting go of the opposition to their goals.

Sustain talk

Language that supports the avoidance of change.

Motivational Interviewing in Practice

With motivational interviewing, fitness professionals want to create an environment where clients feel unconditionally supported and safe to express their feelings. If they feel the fitness professional lacks empathy or is judgmental, they may become closed off and less motivated to share or continue. These can result in what is known as **discord**. Discord is a breach in the fitness professional–client relationship, which can pull attention away from the original relationship intention.

Discord can decrease willingness to change, and, if a client is already prone to sustain talk, it can increase the perception that change is simply too hard. This is the opposite of what professionals want. When clients express sustain talk, they need to feel heard. The fitness professional should use open-ended questions and empathizing to redirect the conversation back toward change talk. Using the previous example for a client engaging in sustain talk, here is a fitness professional's response in that situation that could cause discord (**Figure: Discord**):



FigureDiscord
Discord

A breach in the fitness professional–client relationship that can pull attention away from the original relationship intention.

It is easy to see how this response can evoke discord and more ambivalence in a client. Here is a response to the same question that acknowledges the client's dislikes and preferences and promotes change talk (**Figure: Promoting Change Talk**):

This response clearly states the client is being heard. The professional is respecting their individuality and attempting to help develop a flexible approach and find an amicable solution. This can be the difference between a client continuing to move forward or regressing and giving up altogether.



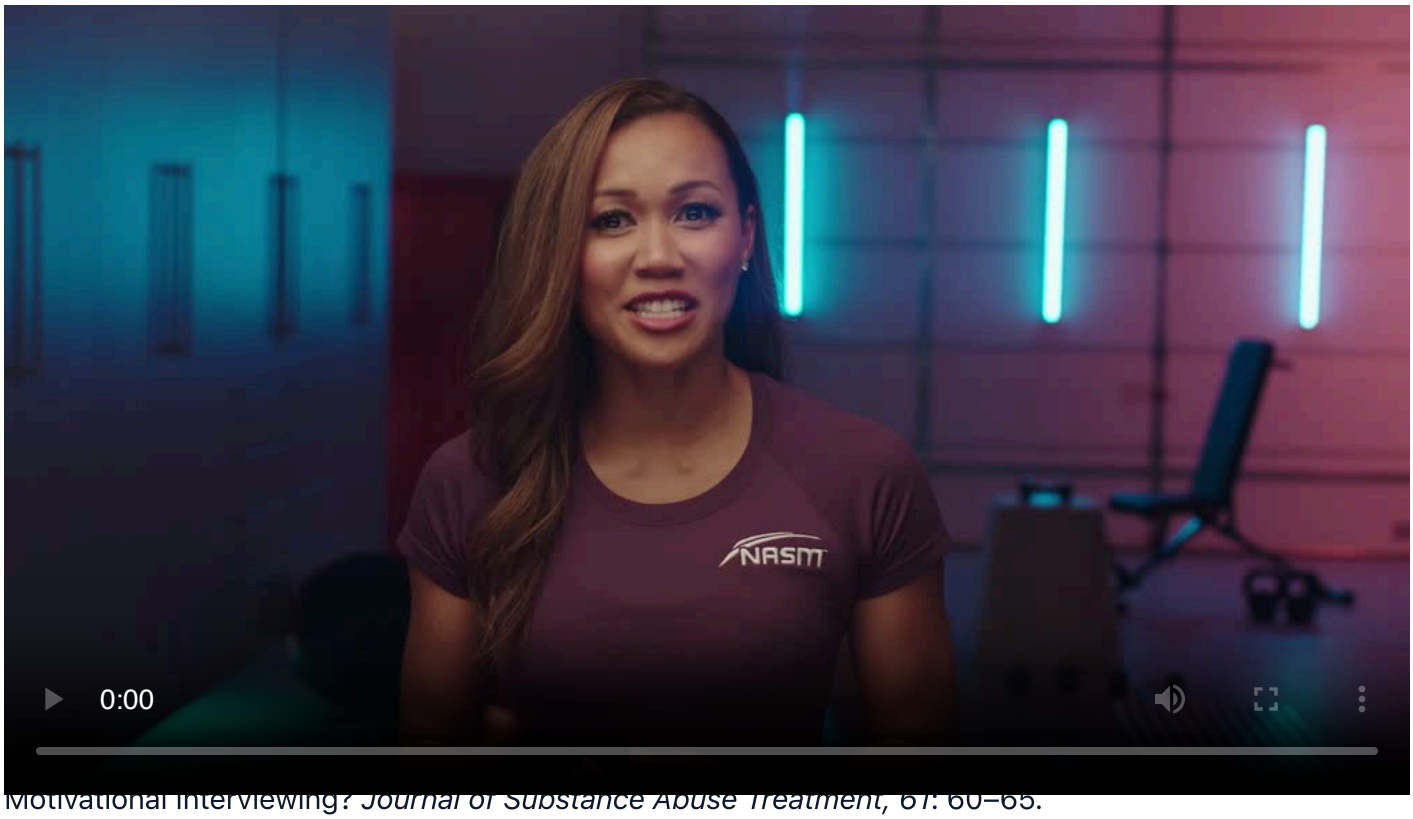
FigurePromoting Change Talk

As much as possible, fitness professionals want the relationship between them and their clients to be a collaborative one. Professionals should help clients explore the deeper reasoning behind their obstacles, find a lifestyle that supports their values and goals in balance, and develop the tools to self-evaluate, self-monitor, reflect, and adapt. This is precisely why motivational interviewing, empathy, and great communication are crucial skills to develop as fitness professionals. If the fitness professional and client work together to develop bespoke approaches to goal achievement, it is likely that the client can sustain for the long-term. It is up to fitness professionals to help clients navigate and invest in their current and future health, rather than find a temporary goal and regress back to their old habits. The goal must be realistically attainable as well as sustainable.

Whatever the reasons for using motivational interviewing, it can help clients move past ambivalence to change talk by allowing them to explore their reasoning in an environment that is safe from judgement and encourages them to align their behaviors to their values.

Summary

Virtual communication is a relatively new platform and environment for fitness professionals and clients all over the world to come together and interact. More recently and more frequently, there are an abundance of opportunities for fitness professionals to work with and help clients from a distance, regardless of physical proximity. Fitness professionals have a variety of options for working with clients virtually, from email to web and mobile-based software applications and asynchronous or synchronous communication strategies—enabling them to find the right fit for clients and themselves. Fitness professionals help their clients through the process of planning and setting goals and then achieving those goals through an individualized, tailored, and achievable process. Through an organized process of data collection and analysis, and consistency in communication, fitness professionals can use their knowledge, skills, abilities, and talents to keep clients accountable and work through periods of issues of ambivalence and hardship. Ultimately, fitness professionals will use empathy and evidence-based methods to help clients realize and achieve their own goals and dreams, all while building an unshakable relationship, which can influence and enhance the lives of the client and fitness professional for a lifetime. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.



NASM VCS Lecture CH4
00:08:15

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